greater objective and the sense of embarking on a great adventure, and at its most primal level, and at least in the early days, the Yatra was a physical and mental challenge that tested most participants.

The first few weeks were perhaps the most challenging, but soon the bodies hardened and the mind learnt to contemplate the next day's journey with serenity. By the time they had crossed Kerala, the yatris had acquired a new physical and mental balance. Once something to marvel at, a day count of 25,000 to 30,000 steps on the pedometer became unremarkable. Indeed, halfway through, some of the younger yatris took to playing games of volleyball in the evening, apparently because the day's 20-kilometre walk hadn't been sufficient exercise.

And the yatris came from everywhere. From the son of a former chief minister of Kerala to a twenty-six-year-old party worker from Uttar Pradesh; from a woman who had left her infant at home to a seventy-six-year-old party legend. The yatris were a microcosm of all India, and its stunning geographical, cultural, religious and social diversity.

Their Working Day

The average day of the yatri merits some recounting, not the least because it's the easiest way to understand their unique world. They would be up at 4–4.30 a.m., an early start to the long day ahead, to the sound of hymns wafting through the camp, the most popular and oft-repeated being 'Vaishnava Jan To Tene Kahiye' or 'Raghupati Raghav Raja Ram'. As we approached the winter months, the mornings became colder until the water began freezing and had to be heated in massive, cylinder-gas-fuelled containers for the yatris' ablutions.

The scene then shifted to the breakfast tent, where you would find your mates slumped over hot cups of milk or tea or coffee, or a sandwich or a pakora. Some would be alone in quiet contemplation, others in muted groups, tendrils of whispered conversations floating in the chilly air.